

The Defenders' Perspective

The defense has a plan too: it starts with the opening lead and goes on by reading the cards as they fall.

1 The goal

Defeat the contract

If North-South need 9 tricks, East-West need only 5.

The opening lead is an edge

The player on declarer's left makes it: it is the first move of the defensive plan.

No hurry

Like declarer, the defense does not cash its winners at once: they are needed to establish tricks.

2 Which suit to lead

Your longest suit. With two of equal length, the one with better honors.

♠ J104 ♥ QJ103
♦ J762 ♣ K2

Four hearts and four diamonds:
hearts, better honors → ♥

♠ Q9732 ♥ KQ
♦ AJ62 ♣ 92

The long suit is spades
→ 2♠

♠ A4 ♥ 94
♦ A762 ♣ KQJ92

Clubs, no doubt → ♣.
Cashing the aces gives tricks away.

3 Which card to lead

Honors: A K Q J 10

Spot cards: 9 down to 2

1 · Top of a sequence

Three high cards in a row, or nearly: KQJ, QJ10, KQ10, AQJ. Lead the highest of the touching cards.

KQJ103 K · denies A, shows Q
K10543 3 · holds an honor

2 · Low from an honor

At least the jack but no sequence: lead your lowest card.

QJ93 Q · denies K, shows J
AJ952 2 · holds an honor

3 · Second highest

No sequence and nothing above the 10: lead the second card from the top.

J1094 J · denies Q, shows 10
108654 8 · no honor

4 Third hand

N ♥ 82
W ♥ KJ754 E ♥ Q96
S ♥ A103

Try to win. West leads the 4: East plays the queen. With a low card, South wins the 10 and takes two tricks.

N ♠ 872
W ♠ KQ1053 E ♠ A4
S ♠ J96

Don't block. West leads the king: East overtakes with the ace and returns the suit. West cashes five tricks.

Return partner's suit whenever you can, unless dummy and your own cards say to switch.

5 Third hand: lowest

With equal cards, third hand plays the lowest. The player who leads plays the highest.

WITH	LEADING	THIRD
K Q J	K	J
A K Q	A	Q
J 10 9	J	9

N ♦ 754
W ♦ 2 E ♦ KQ106
S ♦ ?
2 led → ♠

N ♣ 543
W ♣ 6 E ♣ AK2
S ♣ ?
6 led → ♠

6 The leader's inference

The card third hand plays to win the trick denies the card just below it.

You lead the 3, East plays the **jack**, South wins with the **queen**.

N ♠ 842
W ♠ K9653 E ♠ J?
S ♠ Q?
what you see

N ♠ 842
W ♠ K9653 E ♠ J7
S ♠ AQ10
what you infer

With J10 East would have played the 10, with the ace East would have played it: **South has the 10 and the ace**. Don't lead the suit again; wait for partner to lead it.